DIGITAL FORENSIC EXAMINATION REPORT

Examination of a departing employee's devices and cloud accounts

Data movement, deletion activity and timeline, 19 August to 4 September 2026

SAMPLE

CLIENT	[Redacted] – Ontario professional services firm
INSTRUCTED BY	[Redacted], external litigation counsel
MATTER NO.	DF-2026-0417
REPORT DATE	30 September 2026
VERSION	1.0 Final
CLASSIFICATION	Restricted – counsel and named recipients only

Sample document. This is a fictional specimen prepared to illustrate the structure of an ITRS forensic deliverable. The client, custodian, devices, hash values, events and findings are invented and do not relate to any real matter.

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IMPORTANT NOTICE

This report has been prepared by IT Rapid Support Inc. at the direction of external counsel, in contemplation of litigation, and is subject to solicitor-client and litigation privilege. It is intended solely for counsel and the named recipients and must not be disclosed, copied or relied upon by any other party without ITRS's written consent.

The findings are based on the evidence items listed in section 4 as they existed when acquired, and on the limitations in section 8. ITRS has not audited or verified information supplied by the client except where stated.

Times are Eastern Time (EDT, UTC−04:00) unless labelled otherwise. Personal identifiers have been replaced with role descriptions or initials.

1 Executive summary

IT Rapid Support Inc. (“ITRS”) was retained by external counsel to the client to examine devices and cloud accounts used by a senior employee (“the Custodian”) who resigned on 28 August 2026 and left the firm on 4 September 2026. Counsel asked whether client files were removed or deleted before the Custodian’s departure.

Four evidence items were preserved under chain of custody and examined between 9 and 25 September 2026. Our conclusions on each question are summarized below and detailed in section 7.

1,284	3.6 GB	412	4
files copied to USB storage on 27 Aug	volume of the USB copy	OneDrive files deleted, all recovered	evidence items, hash-verified

NO.	QUESTION	CONCLUSION	CONFIDENCE
Q1	Was firm data copied to external storage?	Yes. 1,284 files (3.6 GB) from the client file share were copied to a USB storage device on 27 August 2026 (F1).	HIGH
Q2	Was firm data sent to personal cloud or email accounts?	Indicators of upload to a personal cloud storage service on 28 August (F2). No forwarding of firm email (F5).	MODERATE
Q3	Were steps taken to delete or conceal activity?	Yes. Browser history was cleared on 3 September and 412 OneDrive files were deleted on 4 September (F3, F4).	HIGH
Q4	Does the mobile device hold firm documents?	No firm documents or transfer indicators were identified on the mobile device (F6).	MODERATE
Q5	Can the files involved be identified?	Yes. Each of the 1,284 files is listed by path, size and time at Exhibit C for counsel’s review.	HIGH

> All 412 deleted OneDrive files were recovered intact from the second-stage recycle bin. The USB device used on 27 August has not been produced; its contents are known only from artefacts on the laptop and file server.

2 Background and instructions

2.1 The client is an Ontario professional services firm. The Custodian held a senior advisory role with access to the firm's client file share and a firm-managed Microsoft 365 account. The Custodian gave notice on Friday 28 August 2026 and confirmed an intention to join a competing firm.

2.2 On 8 September 2026 counsel instructed ITRS to preserve and examine the Custodian's firm-issued devices and accounts. ITRS acted on counsel's instructions throughout; this report is prepared for the purpose of anticipated litigation and is subject to legal privilege.

2.3 ITRS has no prior relationship with the Custodian and no interest in the outcome of the matter. The examiners' duty in preparing this report is set out in section 9.

3 Scope and questions examined

3.1 The examination covered the period **19 August 2026 00:00 to 4 September 2026 23:59** (Eastern Time), being the fourteen days before notice and the notice period. Activity outside that window was reviewed only where it explained an in-scope event.

3.2 Counsel asked ITRS to address the following questions:

Q1	Was firm data copied from firm systems to external storage media during the review period?
Q2	Was firm data transferred to personal cloud storage or personal email accounts?
Q3	Were steps taken to delete firm data or to conceal user activity?
Q4	Does the firm-issued mobile device hold firm documents or evidence of their transfer?
Q5	Can the files involved be identified individually for counsel's review?

3.3 Out of scope: personal devices and accounts of the Custodian, which were not made available; review of document content for privilege or relevance, which remains with counsel; and any opinion on the Custodian's intent, which is a matter for the trier of fact.

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4 Evidence acquired and chain of custody

4.1 Each item was acquired by an ITRS examiner, hashed at acquisition and re-verified before analysis. Working copies were used for all analysis; original images are held on encrypted, access-logged storage at ITRS, Vaughan.

ITEM	DESCRIPTION	ACQUISITION METHOD	ACQUIRED (ET)	SHA-256 (ACQUISITION = VERIFICATION)
E01	Firm laptop, Windows 11 Pro, 512 GB NVMe, BitLocker. Serial …4QK7	Physical image, hardware write-blocked	2026-09-09 10:14 · J.R.	11a08f1b10f227394d8100b3980aea7825ba0b980f8db89a64f2fe39383cfdf0
E02	Firm mobile phone, iOS 26.0.1, 256 GB. IMEI …0193	Full-file-system extraction	2026-09-09 13:02 · M.T.	3d37112d889b59d7a23e24bc701d2cb99b6c7dc76506e6ce648654412a6db2f5
E03	Microsoft 365 account: mailbox, OneDrive, audit log	Logical cloud collection, read-only role	2026-09-10 09:30 · J.R.	07c7b4b5d48d4941d9e305d28af38ecc7c3c378c48ddbe0521ac626e3faa8e0e
E04	File server security event logs (IDs 4656/4663)	Logical export, observed by ITRS	2026-09-10 11:45 · M.T.	f05694dd9085d10835bb6f94b0e9c3d91e930282d3ab7416eb2c30244e7c15ce

4.2 Chain of custody

DATE / TIME (ET)	ITEM	ACTION	FROM	TO
2026-09-04 17:30	E01–02	Returned by Custodian; powered off and bagged	Custodian	Firm IT
2026-09-09 09:05	E01–02	Collected in sealed bags 0417-01/02, seals intact	Firm IT	J.R.
2026-09-09 10:14	E01	Imaging 10:14–12:41; hashes matched	J.R.	J.R.
2026-09-09 13:02	E02	Extraction 13:02–14:26; hashes matched	J.R.	M.T.
2026-09-10 09:30	E03	Cloud collection 09:30–11:02; export hashed	—	J.R.
2026-09-10 11:45	E04	Event-log export hashed on receipt	Firm IT	M.T.
2026-09-10 16:20	E01–02	Resealed (bags 0417-03/04); placed in evidence safe	M.T.	Evidence store

> Custody forms signed at each transfer are reproduced at Exhibit A. Hash verification reports are at Exhibit B.

5 Methodology and tools

5.1 The examination followed ITRS's documented procedures, which are aligned with ISO/IEC 27037 (identification, collection, acquisition and preservation of digital evidence) and NIST SP 800-86 (integrating forensic techniques into incident response). Examiners kept contemporaneous notes for every step (Exhibit G).

01

Preserve

Write-blocked physical imaging of storage; full-file-system mobile extraction; read-only cloud collection. No examination was performed on original media.

02

Verify

SHA-256 computed at acquisition and recomputed on every working copy before analysis. All values matched (section 4).

03

Analyze

Artefacts parsed and correlated across sources: USB device history, file-system and link-file records, browser history, cloud audit events and mobile application data.

04

Validate

Each finding was confirmed by at least two independent artefacts or tools, and reviewed by a second examiner before inclusion.

5.2 Tool categories used

CATEGORY	PURPOSE IN THIS MATTER	VALIDATION
Hardware write-blocker (NVMe / USB 3)	Prevent any write to E01 during imaging	Function-tested before use; test log in Exhibit G
Commercial forensic analysis suite	Parse Windows artefacts (registry, link files, Jump Lists, ShellBags, browser data) and build a unified timeline	Key results reproduced with a second tool
Mobile extraction and analysis platform	Full-file-system extraction and parsing of E02 application databases	Sample records checked against raw SQLite databases
Open-source registry and event-log parsers	Independent parsing of USB device history and file server events 4656/4663	Cross-checked against the commercial suite output
Microsoft Purview audit search	Export of Unified Audit Log, mailbox rules and OneDrive activity for E03	Record counts reconciled with export manifest

5.3 Tool names and exact versions are recorded in Exhibit G. Times in this report are shown in Eastern Time (EDT, UTC−04:00). Source artefacts recorded in UTC were converted programmatically; the original UTC values are retained in the exhibits.

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6 Timeline of findings

6.1 The timeline below lists the events material to the questions in section 3. The full correlated timeline (6,912 events) is produced at Exhibit C.

DATE	TIME (ET)	EVENT	SOURCE	ARTEFACT
2026-08-19	21:42	Personal webmail account signed in through Chrome on the firm laptop	E01	Browser login data
2026-08-27	18:52	USB storage device “DataTraveler 64 GB” (serial ending …7F3A) first connected as drive E:	E01	Registry, setup log
	18:58–19:41	1,284 files read from the client file share and written to E:; 3.6 GB in total	E01, E04	Link files, ShellBags, events 4663
	19:44	USB device last removed	E01	Registry, event log
2026-08-28	08:31	Resignation email sent to the managing partner	E03	Mailbox
	12:07–12:22	Personal cloud storage upload page visited; file-picker dialog opened on E:\Clients	E01	Browser cache, Jump Lists
2026-09-03	17:20	Chrome history, cookies and cache cleared for “all time”	E01	Browser preferences
2026-09-04	16:05–16:11	412 files deleted from OneDrive folder “Client Working Papers”	E03	Unified Audit Log
	16:13	First-stage recycle bin emptied	E03	Unified Audit Log
	17:30	Laptop and phone returned to firm IT; custody begins	—	Custody form

> Events on 27 August are corroborated by two independent sources: link-file and ShellBag records on the laptop (E01) and object-access events on the file server (E04). File server times match laptop times to within two seconds.

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7 Key findings

7.1 Each finding is stated with the evidence on which it rests and a confidence level defined in Appendix B.

F1 **Client files were copied to a USB storage device on 27 August 2026.** HIGH

A USB device not issued by the firm was connected for 52 minutes. Link files and ShellBags record folders under E:\Clients being opened during that session, and the file server logged reads of the same 1,284 files by the Custodian's account at matching times. 212 of the files belong to client folders not assigned to the Custodian.

EXHIBIT C, D

F2 **Firm files were probably uploaded to a personal cloud storage service on 28 August 2026.** MODERATE

Cached pages show the upload screen of a consumer cloud storage service signed in to a personal account, and a Jump List records a file-picker opened on E:\Clients. Browser history for the period was later cleared (F3), so the number of files uploaded cannot be determined.

EXHIBIT D

F3 **Browser history was deliberately cleared on 3 September 2026.** HIGH

Chrome preference records show a manual "clear browsing data" action with an "all time" range at 17:20. Firm policy does not clear browser data automatically. ITRS expresses no view on the reason for the action.

EXHIBIT D

F4 **412 OneDrive files were deleted on the last working day; all were recovered.** HIGH

The Unified Audit Log records 412 FileDeleted events in six minutes, followed by the first-stage recycle bin being emptied. All files were restored from the second-stage recycle bin and hash-matched to earlier versions.

EXHIBIT E

F5 **No firm email was forwarded to personal accounts.** HIGH

No inbox or transport forwarding rules existed in the review period, and no messages were sent from the mailbox to personal domains.

EXHIBIT E

F6 **No firm documents were found on the mobile device.** MODERATE

No firm documents, file-share paths or cloud-storage transfers were identified. One third-party messaging app stores content in an encrypted container that the extraction could not fully parse (section 8).

EXHIBIT F

SAMPLE

8 Limitations and assumptions

8.1 The USB device used on 27 August has not been produced. Its current contents, and whether files were later copied elsewhere, cannot be determined from the evidence examined.

8.2 Browser data cleared on 3 September could be recovered only in part. Finding F2 relies on cached pages and Jump List records, not on a complete browsing history.

8.3 One third-party messaging application on E02 stores content in an encrypted container. Message metadata was available; message content and attachments were not.

8.4 File server logs were produced by firm IT. ITRS observed the export and hashed it on receipt, but did not have direct access to the server.

8.5 Attribution of activity to the Custodian rests on the Custodian's credentials, device possession records and the absence of other interactive logons in the review period. ITRS cannot identify who was physically at the keyboard.

8.6 This report reflects the evidence available on 25 September 2026. ITRS reserves the right to revise its conclusions if further evidence, including the USB device, becomes available.

9 Examiner's declaration

9.1 We confirm that the facts stated in this report are within our own knowledge or are drawn from the evidence identified, and that the opinions expressed are our own, fairly and objectively given. We understand that our duty is to assist the court and that this duty overrides any obligation to the party by whom we are engaged. A signed Acknowledgement of Expert's Duty (Form 53, Ontario Rules of Civil Procedure) is provided at Exhibit H.

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A Appendix A – Exhibit list

EXHIBIT	DESCRIPTION	FORMAT	EXTENT
A	Evidence register and signed chain-of-custody forms	PDF	7 pp.
B	Hash verification reports, items E01 to E04	PDF	4 pp.
C	Correlated timeline, 19 Aug to 4 Sep 2026 (6,912 events) and USB file list (1,284 files)	XLSX	2 sheets
D	Windows artefact extracts: USB history, link files, ShellBags, Jump Lists, browser data	XLSX	5 sheets
E	Microsoft 365 Unified Audit Log extract and mailbox rule report	XLSX	3 sheets
F	Mobile extraction summary and application inventory, item E02	PDF	12 pp.
G	Examiner contemporaneous notes, tool versions and validation logs	PDF	18 pp.
H	Acknowledgement of Expert's Duty (Form 53), signed	PDF	2 pp.

> Exhibits are produced to counsel on encrypted media with a SHA-256 manifest. They are not reproduced in this sample.

B Appendix B – Confidence scale

LEVEL	MEANING
HIGH	Supported by two or more independent artefacts or sources, with no contrary evidence identified.
MODERATE	Supported by at least one reliable artefact; corroboration is partial or some relevant data is unavailable.
LOW	Indicated by circumstantial artefacts only; stated so that counsel is aware of it, not relied on in the conclusions.

END OF REPORT

SAMPLE